

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called 'The Eight Maṇḍalas'

Ārya-aṣṭa-maṇḍalaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 644 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 644 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-aṣṭa-maṇḍalaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra and in Tibetan as Phags pa dkyil 'khor brgyad pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, rendered in English as "The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called 'The Eight Maṇḍalas.'" The text belongs to the sūtra class of canonical Buddhist scripture and is set at Potalaka, the celestial abode of the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, where the Buddha is surrounded by a vast assembly of bodhisattvas and is prompted to teach by the bodhisattva Ratna-hṛdaya-candra-prabhā. As its title suggests, the sūtra's central concern involves the theme of eight maṇḍalas, sacred ritual or contemplative diagrams that carry significance within Mahāyāna practice. It was translated into Tibetan by the monk Chökyi Sherab and established as part of the Kangyur, the Tibetan collection of texts regarded as the word of the Buddha.

And it was translated, edited, and established by the Tibetan translator, the monk Chökyi Sherab.

In the language of India: Ārya-aṣṭa-maṇḍalaka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra.

In the Tibetan language: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called "The Eight Maṇḍalas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling at Potalaka, the abode of the noble Avalokiteśvara, together with many hundreds of thousands of ten millions of bodhisattvas. Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Ratna-hṛdaya-candra-prabhā — Moonlight of Jewel Essence — who had gathered in that very assembly of bodhisattvas, rose from his seat, arranged his robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and, bowing with palms joined toward the Blessed One, addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"If the Blessed One would grant me the occasion to ask, and having asked, to receive a prophetic declaration in reply, then I would put a certain matter to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha."

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke thus to the bodhisattva, the great being, Ratna-hṛdaya-candra-prabhā:

"Ratna-hṛdaya-candra-prabhā, ask whatever you wish, and I, having answered each question with a prophetic declaration, shall gladden your mind."

When the Blessed One had so spoken, the bodhisattva, the great being, Ratna-hṛdaya-candra-prabhā addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, if a son of noble family or a daughter of noble family should wish to perform the eight-maṇḍala ritual, how should they proceed?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of noble family, it is excellent that the courage to accomplish the unrivalled gnosis of sentient beings born in the three times, for the great benefit of the many and the happiness of the many, has arisen in you. Excellent! Excellent! Son of noble family, therefore, listen to the heart-essences of the eight bodhisattvas — the mere recitation of which will avert the five acts of immediate retribution (Skt. ānantarya) and will bring the attainment of all accomplishments.

Oṃ mahā hūṃ mahā vīra svāhā.

This is the heart-essence; it venerates the Blessed One at the center.

Oṃ hrī hūṃ padma priya svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of the noble Avalokiteśvara.

Oṃ mai hā rāṇa svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of Maitreya.

Oṃ ākāśa garbhāya svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of Ākāśagarbha.

Oṃ svā hri rāya jva svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of Samantabhadra.

Oṃ kuru bha na ra ha svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of Vajrapāṇi.

Oṃ śrī aṃ raṃ ga svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of Mañjuśrī, the Youthful.

Oṃ ni svāraṃ bha svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of Sarva-nīvaraṇa-viṣkambhin, the Remover of All Obscurations.

Oṃ kṣiti harā jā svāhā.

This is the heart-essence of Kṣitigarbha.

These heart-essences of the eight bodhisattvas, endowed with the qualities of the Tathāgata: if any son of noble family or daughter of noble family recites them even once before a maṇḍala, all their aims will be accomplished, and they will swiftly and manifestly attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening."

Having thus spoken, the Blessed One concluded. Those bodhisattvas, those great beings, rejoiced and praised the words of the Blessed One.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called "The Eight Maṇḍalas" is complete.

This was translated, edited, and established by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, and by the great editor and translator, the venerable Ye-shes-sde, and was also revised in accordance with the new language conventions.

Translator's Notes

- The sūtra opens with a colophon fragment attributing an earlier translation to the Tibetan monk-translator Chökyi Sherab; a second, fuller colophon at the end names the standard imperial-period team of Jinamitra, Dānaśīla, and Ye-shes-sde with revision into standardized terminology. The two colophons likely reflect different recensions or translation stages.

The maṇḍala in the title and throughout refers to a ritual diagram involving eight bodhisattvas arranged around a central Blessed One. "The eight maṇḍalas" is the number of maṇḍala-fields associated with the eight bodhisattvas listed.

The mantras are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan; the Sanskrit reconstructions are approximate, as tantric seed-syllable strings of this kind often resist neat grammatical parsing.

The "five acts of immediate retribution" (ānantarya-karma) are the five gravest karmic acts — killing one's mother, killing one's father, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and creating a schism in the Saṅgha — which normally lead directly to the lowest hell at death. The text claims that mere recitation of these heart-essences averts even these.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of

spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.